Generating Regime Support in Middle Class Russia: Neo-Soviet vs. Hard-line Conservative Gender/Sexuality Attitudes*

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Abstract

Post-2012 the Putin regime took a conservative shift towards gender and sexuality in its rhetoric and policy. Contrary to this practice, recent literature suggests the president is echoing moderately conservative and pseudo-progressive Neo-Soviet gender/sexuality ideology in his most popular speeches to reach a more moderate middle class. Results from ordered probit models using data from Wave 7 of the World Values Survey demonstrate empirically that conservative and pseudo-progressive attitudes towards women's rights are positive predictors of regime support amongst the Russian middle class. This observation is also true for neo-Soviet attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community, which have not been the subject of prior research. Conversely, hard-line conservative attitudes reflected in Putin's more extreme rhetoric and policy, such as the 2017 partial decriminalization of domestic violence, are not associated with regime support amongst the Russian middle class. The absence of an association between hard-line conservative gender/sexuality positions and government support may suggest that the Putin regime's adoption of such positions in rhetoric and policy is meant to please subsets of influential elites who adhere to traditionalism/ultra conservatism.

Keywords: regime legitimation, gender and sexuality, Russia, ordered probit regression, social survey data

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Introduction

On the 2013 annual television special *Direct Line with Vladimir Putin*, broadcast by all major Russian television stations, the Russian president decried the West for its acceptance of LGBTQ+ people, whom he characterized as pedophiles:

> "You are indeed correct that during my last trip [to Holland] a lot of discussion time was dedicated to the rights of sexual minorities ... But, you see they have their own standards ... if in Holland a court allowed the activities of an organization involved in the spread of pedophilia, then why must we adopt these standards?" (quoted in Sperling et al., 2022).

Scholars identify Putin's explicitly homophobic rhetoric to be part of a conservative shift following a large anti-regime protest movement in 2011/2012. By focusing on traditional views of gender and sexuality as part of the conservative shift, the Putin regime paints itself as a defender of the Russian family while opposing libertine Western immorality (Sperling et al., 2022).[1]

Related gendered/sexual discourse and policies, through which the Putin regime has attempted to legitimize itself and its initiatives since assuming power in 1999, have been the subject of numerous studies (e.g. Gradskova, 2020; Johnson et al., 2021; Riabov and Riabova, 2014; Sleptcov, 2017; Sperling, 2014). Though such studies suggest the Putin regime's gender/sexuality politics (GSP) regime legitimation techniques are effective in various ways (and to various extents), the effect of attitudes about gender/sexuality on regime support have not actually been quantified or demonstrated to be significant.[2] In the post-2012 context, the lack of such research may lead to an overstating *or* understating of the efficacy of GSP rhetoric in generating regime support among middle class Russians.

I use Wave 7 of the World Values Survey to test the the relationship between measures of attitudes towards GSP and regime support among middle class Russian respondents using a series of ordered probit models. In doing so I seek to answer the following research questions: To what extent are attitudes towards women's rights and the LGBTQ+ community associated with support for the Putin regime? How does this connection inform scholarly understanding of Putin's use of GSP-based regime legitimation techniques?

[1] Equating the LGBTQ+ community with pedophilia is a common attack used by anti-LGBTQ+ actors in Russia and elsewhere (Sperling et al., 2022).

[2] Social survey data has been used to a limited extent in related contexts. For instance, scholars use social survey data to examine conservative sentiment among Russians - though attitudes towards GSP are not a focus (Bahry, 2010; Magun and Rudnev, 2010; Shcherbak, 2023).

GSP-based Regime Legitimation in Russia

During the 1990s, the implementation of "shock therapy" and the end of the Soviet-era work assurance policy made the transition to a market economy painful (Gerber and Hout, 1998; Standing, 1997). Russian men were largely confronted with an incapacity to serve as bread-winners, which was now considered the main criterion for masculinity. Combined with Russia's loss of superpower status, the nation experienced collective emasculation (Riabov and Riabova, 2014).

Putin's image was accordingly crafted in parallel with an emerging model of Russian masculinity, *muzhik*, which bears no reference to socioeconomic strata while designating status as a "real man" (Riabov and Riabova, 2014). Putin's brand of masculinity - conveyed by photos of the President riding bare-chested on a horse and videos of him insulting male reporters - developed a popular personality cult and allowed him to establish dominance over other men including potential rivals (Sperling, 2015; Wood, 2016).[3,4] Inherent to Putin's masculinity politics are sexism and homophobia, which strengthen the regime by exacerbating societal divisions and thus underscore the idea that certain people (heterosexual men/autocrats) should rule over others (homosexuals/women/democratic rivals) (Sperling, 2014). Putin's *muzhik* persona promotes images of national masculinity that serve to legitimize the regime (Riabov and Riabova, 2014).

The Putin Regime's Conservative Shift and Traditional Values

During parliamentary elections in December 2011, volunteer election monitors documented election fraud and posted videos on the internet that went viral, sparking large-scale protests in Russia's cities. Residents of Russia's hinterlands largely sided with *muzhik*-Putin who they felt protected their economic interests, and the movement consequently died down by 2012 (Crowley, 2021; Holmes and Krastev, 2013).

Soon after, in August 2012, the prosecution of punk rock group Pussy Riot took the public spotlight. The trial centered around events in February 2012 when Pussy Riot posted a video of its performance in Moscow's Cathedral of Christ the Saviour to the internet and "explained in an interview that it was protesting against the patriarch of the Russian Orthodox Church and calling for the resignation of Putin, whom it considers a 'symbol of the patriarchal mores and sexist bigotry that has plagued our society'" (Riabov and Riabova,

[3]Photo (from 2009 vacation) available here: https://www.nbcnews.com/id/wbna32299822.

[4]Video refers to a 2002 press conference in which a French daily *Le Monde* reporter implied that Russian troops were killing civilians by sowing mines indiscriminately in Chechnya. Putin angrily responded by telling him: "If you are prepared to become the most radical Islamist and are prepared to get circumcised, I invite you to Moscow. We have specialists that deal with this problem" (Traynor, 2002).

2014). Widespread public disapproval of Pussy Riot allowed the regime to concurrently flex its coercive power without opposition, solidify its support base among middle class Russians, and build a connection to the Orthodox Church (Smyth and Soboleva, 2014).

In line with the anti-feminist prosecution of Pussy Riot, the Putin regime continued to shift in a conservative direction following the previously described 2011/2012 protest movement (Evans, 2015; Laruelle, 2013). In particular, the regime began to increasingly promote conservative social attitudes towards women and the LGBTQ+ community through the notion of "traditional values" (Andreeva, Drozhashchikh and Nelaeva, 2021; Edenborg, 2018; Gradskova, 2020; Moss, 2017; Sleptcov, 2017).

This shift is embodied in policies such as a 2013 law that "protects" children from being exposed to homosexual "propaganda," as well as the 2017 partial decriminalization of several forms of domestic violence.[5,6] It is also embodied in frequent statements at public events and in interviews. For instance, referencing his 2013 "gay propaganda" law, Putin urged LGBTQ+ attendees at the 2014 Sochi Olympics to "feel relaxed and calm [in Russia], but leave children alone please" (Putin, 2014).

In the backdrop to all of these events, Russia has experienced a shrinking population from 1999 to 2012 and again from 2016 onward. In 2006, Putin boosted child support payments and initiated cash payments of 250,000 rubles to women who chose to have a second child. More recently, proponents of traditional values have advocated for solving Russia's "demographic problem" by increasing the birthrate among ethnic Russians. To this end, abortion and divorce are depicted as anti-family societal ills (du Quenoy and Dubrovskiy, 2018).

Reflecting Gender and Sexuality Attitudes as Regime Legitimation?

The Putin regime took a conservative shift in the post-2012 context. However, the extent to which the Putin regime has embraced hard-line conservatism and traditional values is disputed in the literature. Moss (2017) argues that the Putin regime has fully embraced

[5]Russia's 2013 anti-gay law "bans the spreading of 'propaganda' of non-traditional sexual relations among minors. The law in effect makes it illegal to equate straight and gay relationships, as well as the distribution of material on gay rights. It introduces fines for individuals and media groups found guilty of breaking the law, as well as special fines for foreigners" (Elder, 2013).

[6]Concerning the partial decriminalization of domestic violence, "first-time offenders who beat their partners or children ... no longer face criminal charges" and if the beatings happen no more than once per year and does not lead to serious harm, abusers only "receive an administrative penalty – either a small fine (the equivalent of around 500 dollars), community service or up to 15 days of detention." In addition, victims of domestic violence are now "responsible for gathering together evidence and bringing a case forward" (Thomson, 2017).

traditional conservative values: "the government, the ruling party, the oligarchs, the state church, the state educational and scholarly establishment and the media all speak with one voice. There is no dialogue, and there is no attempt to hide the sources of [hard-line conservative] anti-gender ideology." On the other hand, Brand and Bluhm (2018) find that the Putin administration has only partially adopted traditional values, while traditional values continue to be "contested within the elite."

Scholarship on the extent to which the Russian middle class buys into hard-line conservative GSP reflected in the traditional values campaign (and whether this legitimizes the regime) is even more mixed. On one hand, the Russian middle class appears to largely exhibit homophobic attitudes characteristic of the traditional values campaign. Sleptcov (2017) and Edenborg (2018) find that the government's politically motivated, explicit homophobia bolsters regime support by depicting the Russian government in opposition to libertine Western modernity. However, in terms of women's rights, Andreeva, Drozhashchikh and Nelaeva (2021) find that the traditionalist ideal of heteronormative marriage is increasingly uncommon in Russia as part of their study. Gradskova (2020) finds that organizations promoting women's rights, family planning, and LGBTQ+ rights had support among Russians prior to the post-2012 traditional values campaign. In short, the degree to which the Putin regime draws support from middle class Russians via GSP is somewhat unclear.

Recently, analysis by Johnson et al. (2021) of Putin's most popular speeches reveal that his post-2012 rhetoric towards women's rights (and likely also towards LGBTQ+ rights, though this is not tested) echoes popular opinion among middle class Russians who are still largely influenced by Soviet ideals. Outside of his most popular speeches, however, Putin's rhetoric emphasizes hard-line conservatism and traditional values. Thus, Putin appears to articulate neo-Soviet attitudes towards women's rights which are moderately conservative and even pseudo-progressive to middle class audiences while delivering hard-line conservative rhetoric (and policy) in less visible settings to appease smaller groups of more conservative Russians (Johnson et al., 2021; Sperling et al., 2022).

Johnson et al.'s (2021) study suggests that Putin is a "weak strongman," balancing benefits across multiple constituencies to maintain power (Frye, 2021). To appease hard-line conservative Russians, Putin uses more extreme rhetoric and policy. To appease Russians who adhere to neo-Soviet GSP ideology, Putin is more restrained. This bifurcated use of GSP rhetoric and policy would appear to explain why scholars seem to disagree on the way in which (1) the regime utilizes GSP; and (2) middle class Russians are concerned with GSP.

Table 1 presents neo-Soviet versus hard-line conservative attitudes towards GSP adapted from Johnson et al. (2021) and Sperling et al. (2022).

TABLE 1 ABOUT HERE

Disparate groups of adherents to more extreme conservative GSP ideology are aggregated in the hard-line conservative column. This is useful because it allows for a binary distinction between Russians whose hard-line conservative beliefs are reflected by the Putin regime's post-2012 extreme rhetoric and policy, and neo-Soviet Russians whose beliefs are reflected in Putin's most popular national addresses.

Existing scholarship thus suggests that GSP may be an effective tool of regime legitimation in Russia though this has not been demonstrated empirically. As outlined above, previous literature suggests that middle class Russians do not strictly adhere to traditionalist hard-line conservative values advanced by the Putin regime's post-2012 campaign.

Instead, the Putin regime appears to generate support among the Russian middle class by espousing popular neo-Soviet GSP attitudes. Such attitudes include general notions of homophobia and moderately conservative/pseudo-progressive attitudes towards women's rights.

Quantifying the Efficacy of Putin's GSP Rhetoric and Policy

The efficacy of the Putin regime's bifurcated use of GSP rhetoric and policy has not been subject to rigorous multivariate testing. The following sections advance and test hypotheses developed from previous qualitative literature suggesting that the Putin regime advances neo-Soviet views to appeal to the majority of the Russian middle class while advancing hard-line conservative views to appeal to small groups of its adherents in and outside the Russian middle class. Broadly, the expectation is that neo-Soviet views on GSP will be positively and significantly associated with regime support among the middle class, while hard-line conservative attitudes will not.

Hypotheses

The following hypotheses, suggested by prior research, are specifically tested:

H1: Neo-Soviet attitudes towards women's rights will be positively associated with regime support among the Russian middle class.

H2: Neo-Soviet attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community will be positively associated with regime support among the Russian middle class.

H3: Hard-line conservative attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community and women's rights will not be associated with regime support among the Russian middle class.

If supported, (H1) will confirm the efficacy of the Putin regime's strategy identified by Johnson et al. (2021) in which the regime echoes neo-Soviet gender ideology in its most popular nationwide speeches in an effort to garner support from the middle class. (H2) extends (H1) by examining the efficacy of neo-Soviet sexuality rhetoric which Johnson et al. (2021) suggests is also an element of Putin's outreach to the middle class (though this is explicitly not tested in their study). If supported, (H2) will confirm the efficacy of neo-Soviet sexuality rhetoric in garnering support from Russia's middle class. Finally, (H3) predicts that middle class Russians do not buy into the Putin regime's hard-line GSP rhetoric and policy, thus confirming prior qualitative literature if supported (Andreeva, Drozhashchikh and Nelaeva, 2021; Gradskova, 2020).

Data and Operationalization of Terms

Cross-sectional data from Wave 7 of the World Values Survey (WVS) is used to test the above hypotheses (Haerpfer et al., 2020). Unfortunately, a direct measure of regime support (i.e. "Do you support president Putin?") is not available in social survey data such as the WVS. Instead, confidence in government is used as a proxy for regime support. I select Wave 7 of the WVS because of its relative recency, the high quality/relevance of its questions pertaining to gender/sexuality, and the availability of confidence in government as a proxy for regime support. These features of the WVS make it a favorable alternative to, for example, the European Social Survey.

The WVS is a cross-national survey that has been administered every five years since 1981. Wave 7 data was collected in Russia in 2017. Interviews were conducted face-to-face at each respondent's place of residence. The data is weighted by demographic variables such as country, age, and sex to ensure that the final sample is representative of the population.[7]

Dependent Variables

The dependent variable used in this study is an ordinal measure of confidence in government which serves as a proxy for regime support. Government confidence is operationalized in the WVS by asking "how much confidence [do] you have in ... government?" Responses are coded 1 for "none at all," 2 for "not very much," 3 for "quite a lot," and 4 for "a great

[7]Documentation available here: https://www.worldvaluessurvey.org/WVSDocumentationWV7.jsp.

deal." I choose government confidence as the proxy for regime support because, though it measures confidence in the government broadly, President Putin is such a defining figure of the Russian government that confidence in government and confidence in Putin are likely strongly positively correlated (though this is not directly testable).

Independent Variables

The independent variables of interest measure attitudes consistent with neo-Soviet and hard-line conservative attitudes towards GSP. Those measuring **neo-Soviet attitudes** are:

1. General homophobia
2. The importance of women's rights
3. The importance of women bearing children

General homophobia is operationalized as attitudes towards the justifiability of being homosexual. General homophobia is coded from 1 (low) to 10 (high). Thus, higher scores indicate greater homophobia.

The importance of women's rights is operationalized through responses to a question which asks respondents to report from 1 (low) to 10 (high) whether "women hav[ing] ... the same rights as men" is an essential characteristic of democracy.

The importance of women bearing children is similarly operationalized through responses to the statement "It is a duty towards society [for women] to have children," coded from 1 (disagree strongly) to 5 (agree strongly). For each neo-Soviet independent variable of interest, higher values indicate a greater degree of adherence to neo-Soviet GSP ideology (see Table 1).

Independent variables of interest measuring **hard-line conservative attitudes** are:

1. Homosexual parenting
2. Overt sexism
3. The justifiability of abortion
4. The justifiability of divorce
5. The justifiability of beating one's wife

Homosexual parenting pertains to the statement: "Homosexual couples are as good parents as other couples." It is coded 1 for strongly agree, 2 for agree, 3 for neither agree nor disagree, 4 for disagree, and 5 for strongly disagree. Higher scores indicate greater homophobia.

Hard-line conservative attitudes towards women's rights are operationalized through several measures. I first create an index of overt sexism by adding responses to the following statements coded 1 for strongly disagree to 4 for strongly agree: "On the whole, men make better political leaders than women do;" "university education is more important for a boy than for a girl;" and "on the whole, men make better business executives than women do." Thus my sexism index ranges from 3 (low sexism) to 12 (high sexism). The Cronbach's alpha for my sexism index is 0.7093, indicating moderate to high internal consistency.

I also use several distinct questions to measure hard-line conservative attitudes towards women's rights. Questions with responses coded low to high from 1-10 are: the justifiability of abortion, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife. Lower scores on the justifiability of abortion and the justifiability of divorce, and higher scores on the justifiability of beating one's wife indicate a greater degree of adherence to hard-line conservative GSP ideology (see Table 1).

Together, these eight measures of attitudes towards GSP allow me to test the extent to which neo-Soviet versus hard-line conservative attitudes are associated with support for the Putin regime. Table 2 displays a correlation matrix of all eight GSP measures. The strongest correlation is between overt sexism and the justifiability of abortion (-0.499), thus illustrating a lack of problematic multicollinearity amongst the independent variables.

TABLE 2 ABOUT HERE

The models presented in this study also include a number of independent controls. These are age, ethnicity, educational attainment, and sex. Age is measured in actual years. For ethnicity, I utilize a dummy variable coded 0 for ethnic Russian respondents and 1 for non-ethnic Russian respondents. Education is an ordinal variable where responses are coded low to high where 1 is no formal education and 9 is a doctoral degree. For sex, responses are coded 0 for male and 1 for female.[8,9]

Socioeconomic status is coded 1 for low, 2 for middle, and 3 for high in the WVS. I filter

[8] I recode homophobia, overt sexism, and sex. See Appendix A for verbatim WVS questions used in the study.

[9] I do not control for party in each model because, for example, government support and attitudes towards GSP both have positive effects on a person's membership in United Russia (Putin's political party). Thus, controlling for United Russia membership opens up a backdoor path from independent variables of interest to government confidence, confounding their relationship in the models.

out respondents in the low and high tiers to capture Russia's middle class alone in each of my models. In other words, cases are limited to middle class Russians.

The spacing across categories in each ordinal independent variable I include in my models is plausibly even. I therefore treat such variables as continuous, as recommended by Pasta and Williams (Pasta, 2009; Williams, 2020).

The unit of analysis in this study is the individual. A total of 1,083 respondents (all of them identified as part of the Russian middle class) are included in the base model below.[10]

Model Specification and Marginal Effects

This paper employs ordered probit regression because its dependent variables are ordinal. The ordered probit regression model that this paper follows is the general specification presented in equation 1:

$$\begin{aligned}\mathbb{P}(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i) =& I[h=1]\Big(\Phi(\kappa_1 - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big) \\ &+ I[2 \leq h \leq 3]\Big(\Phi(\kappa_{h-1} - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta}) - \Phi(\kappa_h - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big) \\ &+ I[h=4]\Big(1 - \Phi(\kappa_3 - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big)\end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

In equation 1, the subscript i represents an entry in the dataset. I is an indicator function. Φ is the cumulative distribution function for the standard normal distribution. Each y_i takes on a category h which has values between 1 and 4 representing low to high confidence in government. As such, $\mathbb{P}(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i)$ represents the probability that y_i takes on the value $h \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$ given $\boldsymbol{x}_i$. Each $\boldsymbol{x}_i$ is a $k+1 \times 1$ vector containing 1 and non-negative integer values for each independent variable. $\boldsymbol{\beta}$ is a $k+1 \times 1$ real number-valued vector containing the intercept and coefficients for each independent variable. The cutoff points $\kappa_1, \ldots, \kappa_3 \in \mathbb{R}$ represent the thresholds at which the y_i's categorization changes to $1, \ldots, 4$ based on the underlying linear model: $y_i^* = \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta} + \varepsilon_i$, where $\varepsilon_i \sim \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma^2)$.

Ordered probit coefficients are not interpretable. Therefore, in addition to ordered probit tables, this paper also reports the marginal effect of significant variables on the probability that a respondent falls into a specific category of the dependent variable. More specifically, this paper examines the derivative of $\mathbb{P}(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i)$ with respect to the j-th independent variable of interest and averages over all respondents in the dataset. This implicitly holds all other variables in the model constant. The result of the derivation to compute the average

[10] Subsequent models utilize fewer respondents due to missing data for added independent variables.

marginal effects (using the chain rule) is given in equation 2 below:

$$\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\frac{\partial}{\partial x_j}\Big[\mathbb{P}\big(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i\big)\Big] = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\beta_j\Big[\phi(\kappa_{h-1} - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta}) - \phi(\kappa_h - \boldsymbol{x}_i^T\boldsymbol{\beta})\Big] \tag{2}$$

In equation 2, N is the number of entries in the dataset and x_j is the j-th independent variable of interest.[11] Average marginal effects are hereby referred to as marginal effects, to be concise.

The marginal effects presented examine the average change in probability a respondent falls into a category for every one point increase in an independent variable. I also report the marginal probability that a respondent falls into a category given a certain independent variable that is held constant. Marginal probabilities are computed as presented in equation 3 below:

$$\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\mathbb{P}\big(y_i = h \mid \boldsymbol{x}_i = (1, x_{i_1}, \ldots, x_{i_j} = c, \ldots, x_{i_k})\big) \tag{3}$$

In equation 3, the model contains k independent variables and c represents the constant at which the j-th independent variable of interest is being held.

Empirical Results

A series of ordered probit models demonstrate the extent to which neo-Soviet versus hard-line conservative views on the LGBTQ+ community and women's rights influence regime support.[12]

Table 3 displays four ordered probit models predicting the proxy for regime support - confidence in government.

TABLE 3 ABOUT HERE

The first model uses control variables alone to predict confidence in government (Table 3, col. 1). Age is a significant positive predictor of confidence in government at the $p < .01$ level. The remaining control variables are not significant.

[11] I compute the average marginal effect (as opposed to the marginal effect at the average) because it allows me to estimate the average effect in the population (as opposed to the effect for the average respondent). Hanmer and Kalkan show that this approach is advantageous because using observed-values to compute average marginal effects "does a better job associating the theoretical framework and data-collection activities with the properties of limited dependent variable models" than marginal effect at the average approaches that compute a typically unobserved value with which to evaluate marginal effects (Hanmer and Kalkan, 2013).

[12] Replicable code available here: https://github.com/nathanenglehart/englehart-2023.git.

The model presented in Table 3, column 2 adds three measures of neo-Soviet GSP attitudes as independent variables to the base model. General homophobia is positive and significant at the $p < .001$ level. The importance of women's rights is positive and significant at the $p < .05$ level, and the importance of bearing children is positive and significant at the $p < .01$ level. As a reminder, higher scores on the general homophobia, women's rights, and bearing children measures are consistent with neo-Soviet views. Initial support for (H1) and (H2) is thus suggested.

The model presented in Table 3, column 3 adds measures of hard-line conservative GSP attitudes to the base model as independent variables. As predicted, homosexual parenting, overt sexism, the justifiability of abortion, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife are not significant predictors of confidence in government. Initial support for H3 is suggested.

The final model (Table 3, col. 4) incorporates both neo-Soviet and hard-line conservative GSP measures in the base model predicting confidence in government. All three indicators of neo-Soviet attitudes remain significant and positive, while all five indicators of hard-line conservative attitudes remain insignificant. In terms of the neo-Soviet GSP measures, the importance of bearing children is positive and significant at the $p < .05$ level. Homophobia is positive and significant at the $p < .05$ level. The importance of women's rights is positive and significant at the $p < .01$ level. Homosexual parenting, overt sexism, the justifiability of aborton, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife are not significant predictors in the full model. Thus, (H1), (H2), and (H3) are all supported.

Aside from sign and significance, ordered probit coefficients are not directly interpretable. Table 4 accordingly reports the marginal effects of the significant variables of interest based on the results in the full model (Table 3, col. 4).

TABLE 4 ABOUT HERE

Among GSP attitudes considered in the final model, the importance of bearing children is the strongest predictor of regime support, posting the highest magnitude across marginal effects. Estimation results suggest that for every one unit increase in the importance of bearing children, the probability that a respondent's confidence in government is "none at all" decreases by 2.05%; "not very much" decreases by 1.07%; "quite a lot" increases by 1.75%; and "a great deal" increases by 1.37%, holding all other variables in the model constant.

Additionally, estimation results suggests that for every one unit increase in general homophobia, the probability that a respondent's confidence in government is "none at all" decreases by 0.959%; "not very much" decreases by 0.500%; "quite a lot" increases by 0.817%;

and "a great deal" increases by 0.641%, holding all other variables in the model constant.

Finally, for every one unit increase in the importance of women's rights, the probability that a respondent's confidence in government is "none at all" decreases by 1.32%; "not very much" decreases by 0.690%; "quite a lot" increases by 1.13%; and "a great deal" increases by 0.885%, holding all other variables in the model constant.

Figure 1 displays a visualization of the aforementioned significant marginal effects. Bearing children has the largest overall effect, followed by women's rights and homophobia.

FIGURE 1 ABOUT HERE

Marginal probabilities of homophobia, the importance of women's rights, and the importance of bearing children are reported in Figure 2. Notice that for each one unit increment in each independent variable of interest, the probability that respondents report their confidence in government as "none at all," "not very much," "quite a lot," or "a great deal" increases by its respective marginal effect. The overall marginal effect of homophobia is not strong enough to flip any probabilities. However, the overall marginal effect of importance of women's rights flips the probability of respondents reporting their confidence in government as "quite a lot" to being greater than "not very much," at score 2. The overall marginal effect of importance of bearing children flips the probability of respondents reporting their confidence in government as "a great deal" to being greater than "none at all," at score 5.

FIGURE 2 ABOUT HERE

The empirical results of this study present all three neo-Soviet GSP attitudes (general homophobia, the importance of women's rights, and the importance of bearing children) as significant positive predictors of regime support, confirming (H1) and (H2). Of these significant predictors, the importance of bearing children has the largest marginal effects, followed by the importance of women's rights and then general homophobia. Hard-line conservative GSP attitudes (homosexual parenting, overt sexism, the justifiability of abortion, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife) are concurrently not significant predictors of regime support, confirming (H3).

Putin's Neo-Soviet versus Hard-line Conservative GSP Rhetoric and Policy in Middle Class Russia

Previous qualitative literature finds that the Putin regime echoes middle class neo-Soviet attitudes in its most popular speeches to garner support from the middle class which does not entirely support its traditional values rhetoric. I demonstrate that this strategy is successful

in fostering positive associations between neo-Soviet attitudes and the government amongst the Russian middle class. In line with my hypotheses, neo-Soviet attitudes (homophobia, the importance of women's rights, and the importance of bearing children) are all positively associated with government confidence - a proxy for regime support. At the same time, the Putin regime's hard-line conservative policy and rhetoric does not generate regime support among middle class Russians. Hard-line conservative attitudes (gay parenting, overt sexism, the justifiability of abortion, the justifiability of divorce, and the justifiability of beating one's wife) are not significantly associated with confidence in government.

These results serve as a quantitative confirmation of the efficacy of the post-2012 GSP strategy Johnson et al. (2021) identifies. It extends their work by demonstrating that Soviet-style opinion about the LGBTQ+ community (homophobic, but not specific hatred in "defense of the Russian family/morals") is associated with regime support.

The Putin regime therefore effectively caters to the Russian middle class through neo-Soviet GSP ideology in the post-2012 context. It follows that hard-line conservative rhetoric is used in a targeted fashion to appease subgroups of hard-line conservatives. The Putin regime nevertheless takes increasingly conservative positions on GSP as it becomes more authoritarian (Gradskova, 2020). This begs the question, why does the Putin regime feel the need to cater to small groups of hard-line conservative Russians to such a great extent?

I propose this may be because some hard-line conservatives are highly influential elites, some of whom have military connections. Billionaire banker/media executive, Konstanin Malofeev, who has financed separatism in Ukraine, has suggested that women should not work and focus on childbearing.

> "Are there many happy women who have made a career? When the Lord gave the commandment to Adam and Eve, he told Adam to earn his bread by the sweat of his brow, and to the women - to give birth to his children in pain" (UCMC, 2023*a*).

Ramzan Kadyrov, head of the Chechen Republic and colonel in the Russian military with a powerful private militia has stated his belief in the justifiability of domestic violence.

> "[A] woman that has married, given birth to children, must know her place. She can be scolded, she can also be beaten, as a mother beats her children" (UCMC, 2023*b*).

Under the leadership of Kadyrov, LGBTQ+ rights have been trampled upon in Chechnya. Following systematic purges of LGBTQ+ Chechens in 2017, Kadyrov denied their occurrence in an interview on HBO stating that "[w]e don't have those kinds of people here. We don't have any gays. If there are any, take them to Canada" (Taylor, 2017).

Malofeev and Kadyrov's views on GSP combined with their notable political power and military connections may be indicative of the pressure felt by the Putin regime to appease

traditionalism and ultra-conservatism among certain highly influential elites. Attendant GSP policy and rhetoric is likely not aimed at garnering support from Russia's middle class. Nor would it be effective based on this study's results, though elite demands likely include campaigns to sway popular opinion. The results of this study therefore encourage future analyses of the influence of elite demands on the Putin regime's GSP rhetoric and policy.

Notes on Study Limitations

The models in this article are subject to some limitations. Confidence in government does not directly measure support for the Putin regime, which would make a preferable regressand (though it is not available in social surveys such as the WVS).

Social desirability bias may plausibly confound the measurement of certain variables, such as the importance of women's rights and the justifiability of beating one's wife. Respondents may feel pressure to feign pseudo-progressive sentiment. If so, the results are likely to overstate the effects of neo-Soviet sentiment and understate the effects of hard-line conservative sentiment.

Social desirability bias likely *does not* apply to attitudes towards the LGBTQ+ community given widespread acceptance of homophobic attitudes in Russia.[13] Social desirability bias is also unlikely to affect measurement of confidence in government. Numerous studies have found that Russian citizens are unlikely to engage in self-censorship or feign positive attitudes towards the regime (Rose, 2007; Shen and Truex, 2021; Wyman, 1997). Pro-regime response bias is unlikely to confound the results of this study.

Discussion

Distinct gender and sexuality politics (GSP) emerged during the post-Soviet period fed by social displacement. Upon taking power, Vladimir Putin co-opted these politics by attaching himself to the *muzhik* male ideal. Following the 2011/2012 protest movement and the Pussy Riot trial, Putin took a conservative shift - especially towards GSP rhetoric and policy.

I hypothesized (H1) that moderately-conservative and pseudo-progressive attitudes towards women's rights and (H2) general homophobic sentiment would be positive, significant predictors of regime support. I also hypothesized that (H3) hard-line conservative sentiment towards GSP would not be predictive of regime support. Each hypothesis was supported.

Middle class Russians' neo-Soviet GSP ideology is being effectively catered to by the

[13] In Wave 7 of the WVS just over 61% of respondents reported the highest degree of general homophobia. Using the same measure, just over 84% of respondents reported some degree of opposition to homosexuality.

regime according to the results above. Anti-LGBTQ+ attitudes and support for moderately conservative/pseudo-progressive attitudes towards gender are most central to neo-Soviet ideology.

Hard-line conservative GSP attitudes are not associated with regime support across models. This suggests that more conservative elements of the regime's GSP strategy, such as the decriminalization of domestic violence, are meant to please small subsets of traditionalist/hard-line conservative Russians (which contain ultra-influential elites with military connections). Hard-line conservative rhetoric and policy is not intended to garner support from middle class Russians. This study's results suggest that such a strategy would be ineffective.

This study demonstrates the usefulness of social survey data in examining questions of gender, sexuality, and politics in Russia and similar countries. Future studies may benefit from related research designs, using social survey data and binary or ordered choice regression models to examine associations between attitudes towards GSP and regime support.

Analyses of GSP politics and authoritarianism may benefit from further research innovation, beyond the addition of multivariate statistical analyses. Increasingly, formerly qualitative sources are available to political scientists for quantitative analysis in large quantities. Opportunities for alternative data sources are especially pertinent in the context of the war in Ukraine and consequential shortage of social survey data.

Tools from the burgeoning field of text as data may be useful in future research. Speech corpora such as Putin's speeches collected by Johnson et al. (2021) or similar collections are available for analysis utilizing discovery, prediction, and causal inference, as used and detailed in numerous books and articles (e.g. Egami et al., 2022; Fong and Grimmer, 2021; King, Lam and Roberts, 2017; Lucas et al., 2015; Nielsen, 2017; Roberts, Stewart and Nielsen, 2020; Ying, Montgomery and Stewart, 2022).

Computer vision may also be a useful tool for the identification and categorization of images online. Torres (Forthcoming) details the implementation of Bag of Visual Words to build an Image-Visual Word matrix for unsupervised and semi-supervised analysis of political images (e.g. using topic models). Chang (2022) uses a self-supervised vision model to learn low-dimension visual embedding of Reddit memes and subsequently clusters them with K-means. In doing so, he identifies Kremlin-produced vs. authentic memes while finding patterns in each data cluster. Notably, Kremlin-produced memes are more likely to feature gender-related themes.

New methods of data-driven, quantitative analysis should be leveraged towards the study of GSP in authoritarian systems to answer pertinent questions not easily addressable with qualitative analyses. For example: What themes are most prevalent across large N corpora

of government statements and which themes relate to GSP? What kinds of GSP-related social media posts do authoritarian governments censor and promote? What is the causal effect of adherence to conservative GSP and propensity to post anti-regime content online? Future studies addressing such questions with quantitative analyses will promote a better understanding of GSP-related regime priorities and their effectiveness in bolstering support.

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Tables

Table 1: Predominant Russian GSP Attitudes

	Neo-Soviet	**Hard-line Conservative**
LGBTQ+	Adherents hold stereotypical homophobic views towards Russia's LGBTQ+ community. They believe that discriminatory policy is not necessary, but neither is protective policy.	Adherents advocate for explicitly discriminatory policy towards LGBTQ+ Russians who they view with disgust. The more-extreme portion of this group believes in vigilante violence against the LGBTQ+ community.
Women's Rights	Adherents believe that while it is important for women to have children, women also deserve the same rights as men since they are fully capable workers (as long as their profession does not interfere with their womanliness).	Adherents not only emphasize the importance of childbearing, but oppose abortion. More extreme adherents oppose divorce and premarital sex, while supporting policy including the decriminalization of domestic violence.

Notes: Adapted from Johnson et al. (2021) and Sperling et al. (2022).

Table 2: Correlation Matrix of Measures of Attitudes Towards GSP

	Overt Sexism	**Justif. Abortion**	**Justif. Beat. Wife**	**Import. Bear. Child.**	**Import. Women's Rights**	**Gen. Homoph.**	**Homosex. Parenting**	**Justif. Divorce**
Overt Sexism	1.0000							
Justif. Abortion	-0.499*	1.0000						
Justif. Beating Wife	0.1139***	0.1171***	1.0000					
Import. Bear. Child.	0.0434	-0.0762**	-0.0018	1.0000				
Import. Women's Rights	-0.1339***	0.1080***	-0.1282***	0.0140	1.0000			
Gen. Homoph.	0.0385	-0.2159***	-0.0953***	0.0559*	0.0101	1.0000		
Homosex. Parenting	0.0622	0.0313	0.1308*	-0.0256*	-0.1214***	-0.0680***	1.0000	
Justif. Divorce	-0.0414	0.5983***	0.0795**	-0.1117***	0.1217***	-0.2083***	-0.0039	1.0000

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Notes: Entries are correlation coefficients. Measurements of gender and sexuality politics (GSP) consist of overt sexism, the justifiability of abortion (justif. abortion), the justifiability of beating one's wife (justif. beating wife), the importance of bearing children (import. bearing children), the importance of women's rights (import. women's rights), general homophobia (gen. homophobia), and the justifiability of divorce (justif. divorce).

Table 3: Modeling Gov. Confidence as a Function of Measures of Attitudes Towards GSP

	Government Confidence			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Controls				
Female	0.0893	0.0340	0.101	0.0484
	(1.36)	(0.49)	(1.35)	(0.62)
Age	0.00526**	0.00517*	0.00382	0.00365
	(2.58)	(2.29)	(1.68)	(1.49)
Education	-0.0221	-0.0265	-0.0121	-0.0146
	(-1.16)	(-1.30)	(-0.57)	(-0.65)
Ethnic Minority	-0.100	-0.156	-0.140	-0.133
	(-1.16)	(-1.58)	(-1.37)	(-1.21)
Neo-Soviet				
Gen. Homophobia		0.0494***		0.0378*
		(3.49)		(2.05)
Import. Women's Rights		0.0328*		0.0522**
		(2.10)		(2.73)
Import Bearing Children		0.0752**		0.0808*
		(2.58)		(2.41)
Hard-line Conservative				
Homosex. Parenting			-0.0104	0.0143
			(-0.42)	(0.38)
Overt Sexism			0.00655	-0.0140
			(0.35)	(-0.68)
Justif. Abortion			0.00306	-0.0113
			(0.19)	(-0.68)
Justif. Divorce			-0.0264	-0.0278
			(-1.61)	(-1.60)
Justif. Beating Wife			-0.0336	-0.00447
			(-1.87)	(-0.22)
Constants				
Cutoff 1	-0.894***	-0.130	-1.087***	-0.336
	(-5.62)	(-0.55)	(-3.57)	(-0.91)
Cutoff 2	-0.0375	0.769**	-0.236	0.570
	(-0.24)	(3.24)	(-0.78)	(1.55)
Cutoff 3	1.212***	2.121***	1.038***	1.937***
	(7.57)	(8.73)	(3.43)	(5.22)
N	1083	951	909	830
pseudo R^2	0.004	0.018	0.007	0.022

Entries are ordered probit coefficients with t statistics in parentheses

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

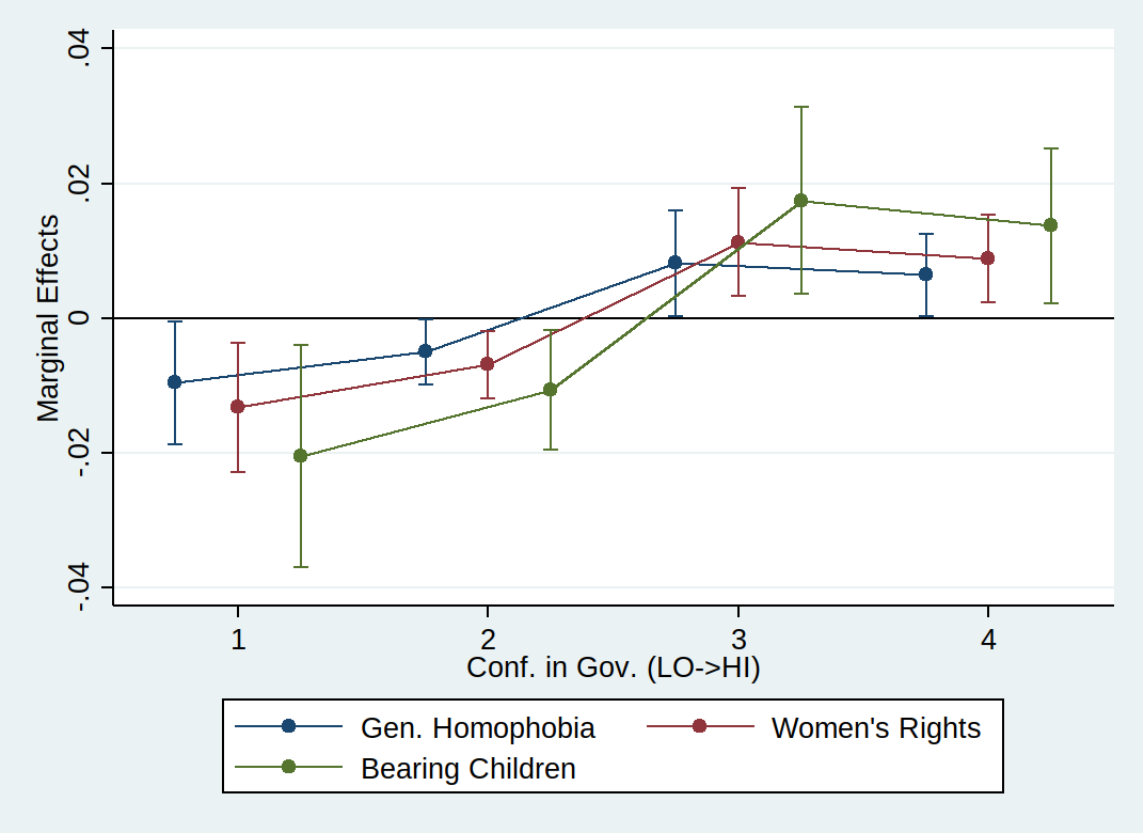
Table 4: Marginal Effects of **Neo-Soviet Attitudes** Towards GSP on Gov. Confidence

	Gov. Confidence
	(1)
Gen. Homophobia	
(1) "none at all"	-0.00959*
	(-2.06)
(2) "not very much"	-0.00500*
	(-2.04)
(3) "quite a lot"	0.00817*
	(2.05)
(4) "a great deal"	0.00641*
	(2.05)
Import. Women's Rights	
(1) "none at all"	-0.0132**
	(-2.71)
(2) "not very much"	-0.00690**
	(-2.71)
(3) "quite a lot"	0.0113**
	(2.74)
(4) "a great deal"	0.00885**
	(2.66)
Import. Bearing Children	
(1) "none at all"	-0.0205*
	(-2.43)
(2) "not very much"	-0.0107*
	(-2.35)
(3) "quite a lot"	0.0175*
	(2.46)
(4) "a great deal"	0.0137*
	(2.33)
N	830
pseudo R^2	0.022

Entries are ordered probit marginal effects with t statistics in parentheses
* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

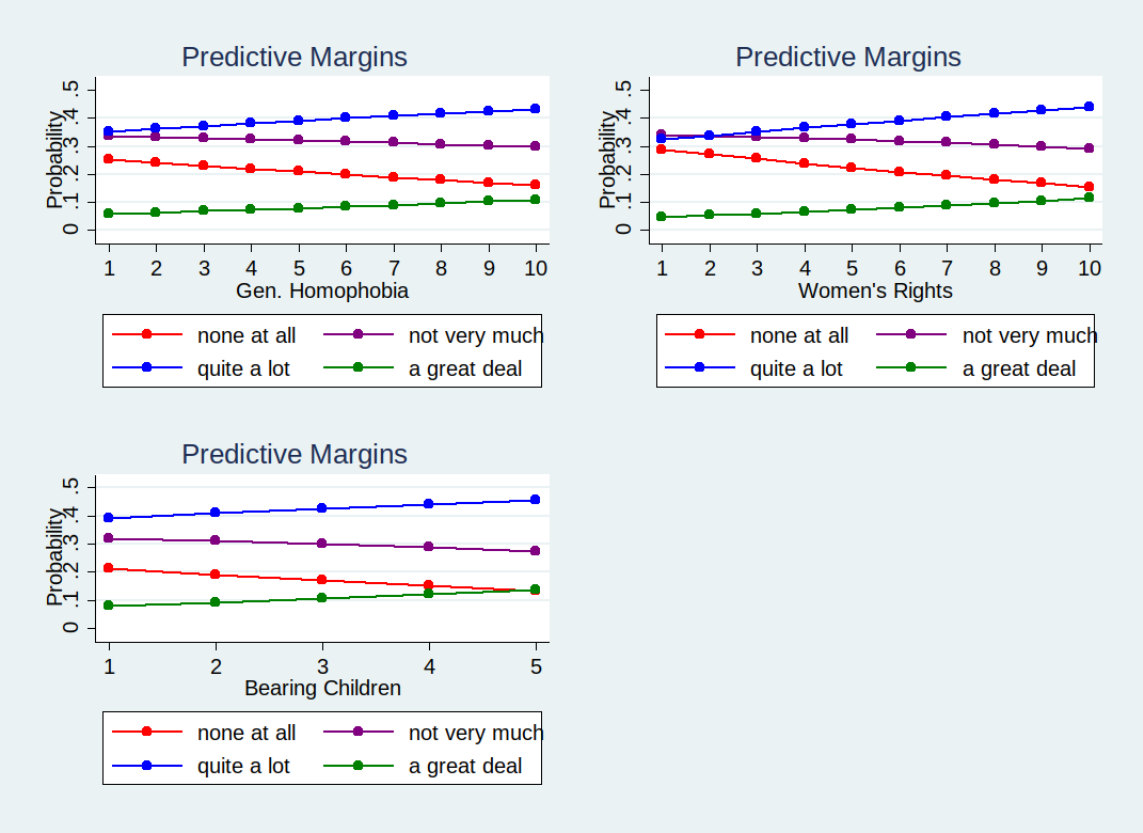
Figures

Figure 1: Marginal Effects of Sig. Attitudes on Gov. Conf.



Notes: This figure presents a visualization of significant marginal effects from ordered probit model of government confidence as a function of gender and sexuality politics (GSP), also reported in Table 4, col. 1. Measures of neo-Soviet GSP (general homophobia, the importance of women's rights, and the importance of bearing children) are significant predictors of confidence in government. Hard-line conservative GSP are not significant predictors of confidence in government and are consequently not presented above. The marginal effects of the importance of bearing children are the greatest overall, followed by women's rights, and then general homophobia.

Figure 2: Marginal Probabilities of Gov. Conf.



Notes: This figure presents a visualization of predictive margins computed using the ordered probit model of government confidence as a function of gender and sexuality politics (GSP) presented in Table 3, col. 4 and Table 4, col. 1. The overall marginal effect of importance of women's rights flips the probability of respondents reporting their confidence in government as "quite a lot" to being greater than "not very much," at score 2. The overall marginal effect of importance of bearing children flips the probability of respondents reporting their confidence in government as "a great deal" to being greater than "none at all," at score 5.